

Parliamentary government

In many older democracies, the system of government evolved as power was gradually shifted from the monarchy to a parliament. Britain is the prime example of such a parliamentary government, which has served as a model for many other parliaments around the world. While a parliamentary democracy may have either a hereditary monarch or an elected president as nominal head of state, the executive power usually rests with a prime minister and cabinet or council of ministers, often referred to simply as ‘the government’, who are also members of the parliament.

In practice, the cabinet can only operate with the support of a majority of the parliament. The policy and decision-making of the cabinet of ministers requires the endorsement of parliament, without which it cannot pass laws. And, if the cabinet or prime minister no longer have the support of a majority of the parliament, there may be mechanisms allowing a vote of no confidence that can remove them from power.

